

STUDENT HANDOUT

RED LEVEL
GO DEEPER

Source Detective

Grades 5–8 · ELA

ADMIT ONE

NAME _____ DATE _____ CLASS _____

The anatomy of misinformation. William Mumler made a fortune selling fake "spirit photographs" in the 1860s. He was eventually put on trial — but not before thousands of grieving families paid for fraudulent images of their dead relatives. Today's misinformation spreads faster and reaches more people than Mumler could have dreamed. Understanding HOW misinformation works is the first step to fighting it.

KEY INSIGHT

Mumler was acquitted at trial because the prosecution couldn't PROVE how he faked the photos — even though experts knew they were fake. Today, deepfakes are becoming nearly impossible to detect. If we can't always prove something is fake, how do we decide what to believe?

01 PART 1

Case Study: Analyze Real Misinformation

With teacher approval, find an example of misinformation that spread online (a viral fake image, a debunked claim, a manipulated video). Analyze it:

What was the false claim or fake image? _____

Apply the CRAAP test — which criteria would have revealed the problem? _____

How did it spread? Why did people believe and share it? _____

How was it eventually debunked? Who did the fact-checking? _____

02

PART 2

Create a Verification Guide

Design a one-page guide for students your age on how to verify information before sharing. Include:

- At least 3 specific tools or techniques (reverse image search, fact-checking sites like Snopes or FactCheck.org, checking original sources, etc.)
- Red flags to watch for (emotional language, no author listed, suspicious URL, etc.)
- A real example showing your verification process step-by-step

Use the back of page 2 or a separate sheet for your guide.

03

PART 3

Critical Thinking Challenge

Consider this: Spirit photographer William Mumler was put on trial in 1869 but was acquitted because the prosecution couldn't PROVE how he faked the photos. Today, deepfakes are becoming nearly impossible to detect even by experts.

Question: If we can't always prove something is fake, how should we decide what to believe? What's the role of trust, reputation, and multiple sources?

MINI MUSEUM DEEP DIVE

Research Question: How did newspapers and scientists eventually expose spirit photography as fraud? What techniques did investigators use, and how do modern fact-checkers use similar methods today?

Historical Context: Spirit photography emerged during the American Civil War, when hundreds of thousands of families were grieving lost soldiers. Mumler charged about $10 — several times the price of an ordinary portrait. He targeted people at their most emotionally vulnerable.

Modern Parallel: Today's misinformation often targets strong emotions: fear, anger, grief, hope. The technology changes, but the psychology remains the same.

minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/seeing-is-deceiving

SHARE WITH YOUR FAMILY

Interview Project: Interview an older family member about how they verified information before the internet existed. Ask them:

- How did you know if something you read or saw was true?
- What sources did you trust? Why?
- What's different about information today?

Compare their methods to yours. What's better today? What's harder?